THE ALL NEW KIRLOSKAR: WHERE EXPERTISE MEETS A FUTURISTIC VISION

The Kirloskars have a glorious tradition of shaping the future. They have been the trendsetters in their industry, introducing innovations that have played a pivotal role. It is this enduring spirit that sees them transforming themselves, as they get ready to power a brave new world to live limitless.

Giving us insights into this process, **George Verghese,** the Vice President, Group HR at Kirloskar, CHRO and Chief of Staff, Kirloskar Oil Engines Ltd. had the following to share...

Q There has been a recent brand refresh, and a change in identity, under the theme Limitless. What does it signify?

The brand refresh is the starting point of an organization-wide change and business transformation effort. We have evolved as an organization over time, staying relevant over the decades. By a brand refresh, we are stating our intent strongly to all stakeholders, both internal and external, that we are changing for the better.

Q How do you approach this transformation in different companies?

Transformation takes a different shape in each of our group companies. We are in various sectors, catering to different customers. We are present across a wide growth spectrum - from very stable mature businesses to startups. While some things like Brand and Values are common, the rest is business-specific. The transformation process is all about creating organizations that continue to deliver value to all our stakeholders.

Q Can you elaborate on the transformation effort in any organization within the Group?

Let us take Kirloskar Oil Engines. We were trying to enable a 75-year old engineering and manufacturing firm to start acting like a startup. This is necessitated by the pace of change in the technology domain and in customer expectations. We went back to the drawing board, to evaluate our core competencies, to recreate an organization for the emerging decade putting in place the structures and the leadership that it needs.

Q What role does the organization culture play in these transformations?

Every business transformation leads to a cultural transformation as well. One cannot happen without the other. My best definition of culture is, "the way we do things here". Culture is an abstract term, it is a sum total of many factors that interplay with each other. We can control what goes into this melting pot, with policies, processes, people, leadership behaviours and so on. And we are rightly focusing on these. We are aiming to create an environment where there is diversity of thought, where people feel confident to take calculated risks without fear of failing.

Q What is different with the new generation of workforce? Are their needs different? How are you addressing them?

There is a change in employee expectations. Simply put, they value fairness, transparency and freedom. Today's workforce realizes that businesses have cycles and one cannot expect double digit increments every year. However, they expect to be treated fairly, with transparency being a basic expectation. Their underlying needs like work from home, flexi working et al is freedom. It gives them the liberty to manage ones affairs optimally, whether it is office or home, without being tied to a place from 9 to 6.

Q The pandemic and post pandemic period saw big disruptions amongst the workforce, with layoffs and wave of resignations signifying them. How did the Kirloskar organizations manage this?

We managed the pandemic without knee-jerk reactions like massive layoffs, staying rooted to our values as a caring organization. It had its rewards. Post pandemic, we did not see the level of resignations that the industry saw. We did have attritions, but lesser than the industry average.

Q How do you see the Group shape up in the next 10 years or so?

We are well placed. We have very strong fundamentals; we have great leadership teams and a great talent pool. We are well poised to make the best out of the favorable macro-economic and geopolitical environment. Our cash positions are strong as well, and I see the Group growing both organically and inorganically, forward and backward integrating to complimentary businesses.

